Impact of accommodated speech on autistic people's evaluation of the speaker

In conversations, speakers often adjust their language to accommodate listeners, especially when they anticipate that the listeners may face comprehension difficulties. Sociolinguistics research has extensively studied accommodation and its impacts on listeners from different social groups, such as different generations (younger and older adults) or language backgrounds (L1 and L2 speakers) [1,2]. These accommodations typically include simplifications such as slower speech, simpler sentences, and more repetitions [1-5]. Despite speakers' helpful intentions behind using such simplified registers, the accommodations may not always be beneficial for listener comprehension and can be perceived as patronizing [6,7].

A less well-studied intergroup context in which linguistic accommodations are also observed is between disabled and non-disabled people [8,9]. Many anecdotal accounts by autistic individuals report being spoken to in a simplified style, though perceptions of these accommodations vary [10-12]. The goal of the present study is to investigate how accommodated speech impacts autistic listeners' evaluation of the speaker.

Sixty-one autistic adults participated (mean age = 33 years; range = 25-45 years). The study used the Map Task paradigm [13]. Participants heard recorded instructions in English from two speakers to draw routes on maps and were asked to follow along. The speakers in the recordings used either a "neutral" register directed to an adult who is not presumed to need accommodations, or a "simplified" register, modeled after *Elderspeak*—another type of accommodated speech register [4]. The registers differ in the following linguistic features: speech rate, syntactic complexity (MLU and clausal density), semantic complexity (e.g., TTR), and discourse features (e.g., number of repetitions). After the Map Task, participants evaluated the speakers (e.g., helpful, condescending, respectful, etc.).

We hypothesized that participants would evaluate speakers who use simplified speech more negatively overall. We also examined whether participants distinguished between ratings of speaker comprehensibility (e.g., instructions were unclear) and interpersonal regard (e.g., speaker was condescending).

Figure 1 shows distribution of participant responses. A cumulative ordinal regression revealed a significant effect of register (simplified vs. neutral) on overall ratings ($\beta = 0.57$; $p < 0.001$). Participants rated speakers who gave instruction in the simplified register more negatively than the neutral register. Looking at the rating items in the two subsets (comprehensibility and interpersonal regard), we found no difference in ratings between registers on perception of comprehensibility ($\beta = 0.32$; $p = 0.13$), but participants rated the simplified register more negatively on perception of interpersonal regard ($\beta = 0.70$; $p < 0.001$).

Autistic listeners evaluated speakers who used simplified speech style negatively, mirroring findings from studies on Elderspeak [4,6-7] and many anecdotal reports from autistic individuals [10-12]. While ratings of speaker comprehensibility did not differ between registers, use of simplified speech was perceived as lacking in interpersonal regard (e.g., the speaker was perceived to be more condescending). Ongoing analysis of Map Task performance will assess actual comprehension, but regardless of comprehension outcomes, these results highlight that simplified speech may inadvertently convey lower regard for autistic people.

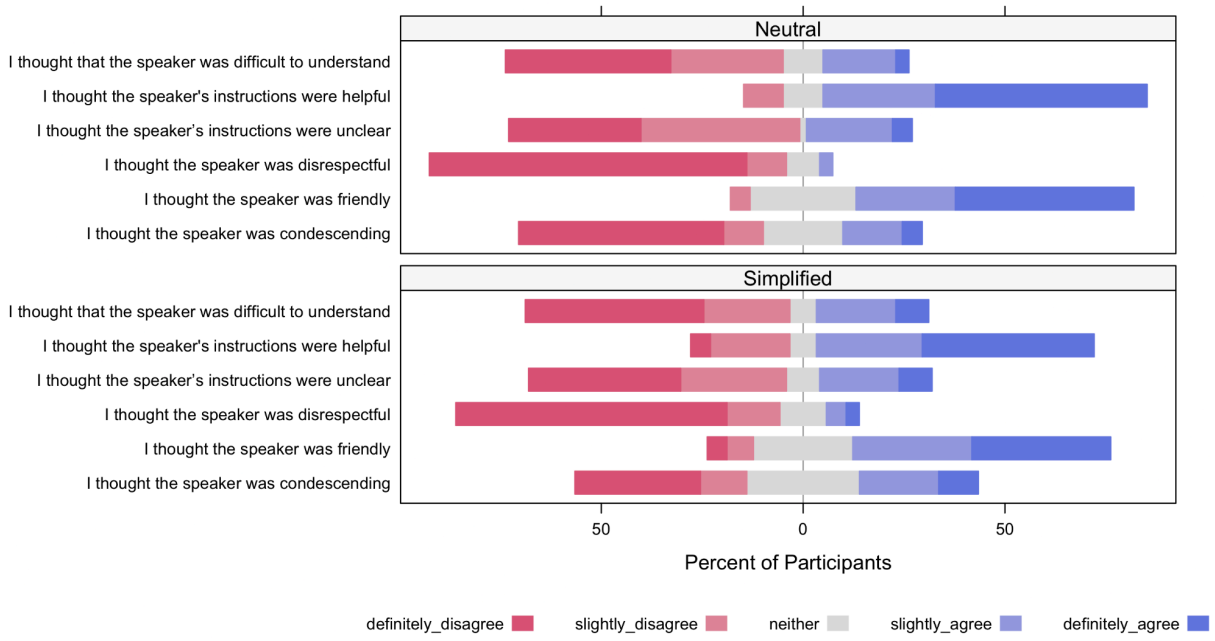

Figure 1. Distribution of responses by register-type.

References

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